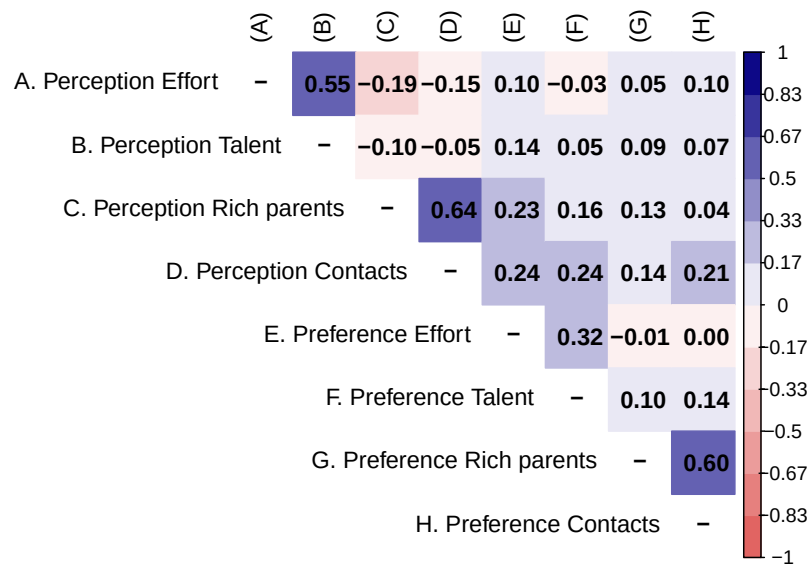


Supplementary material

1 Correlation matrix

Figure 1: Correlation matrix for the pooled sample



2 Confirmatory factor analysis of the meritocracy scale

Figure 2: CFA model for the first wave

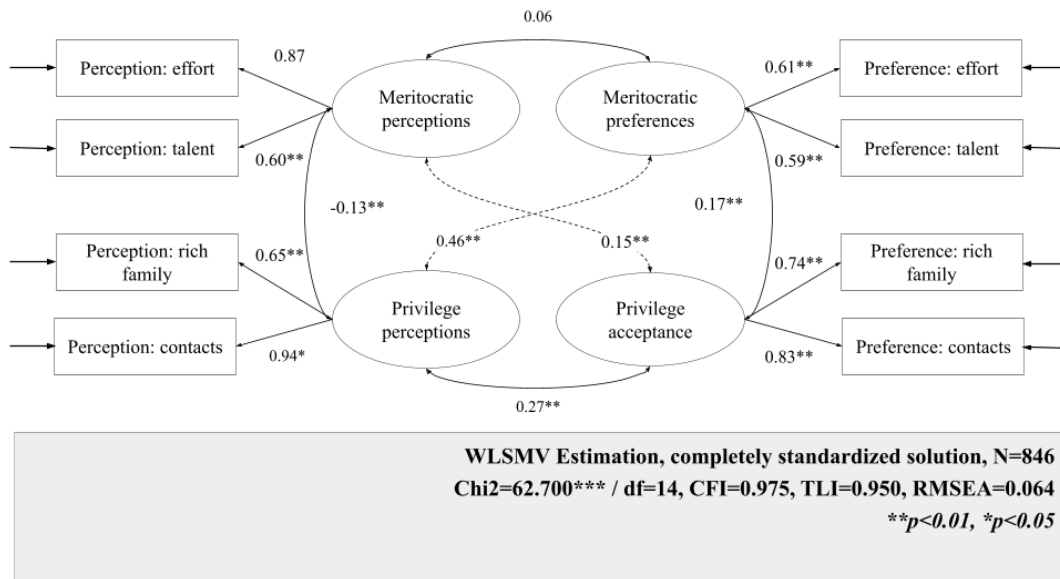


Figure 3: CFA model for the second wave

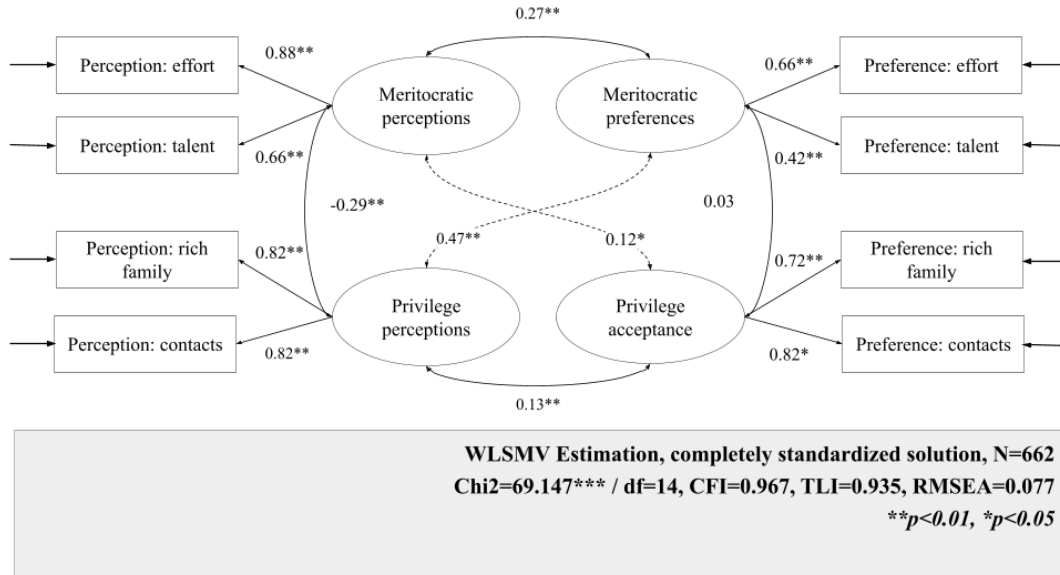


Figure 4: CFA model for the primary cohort

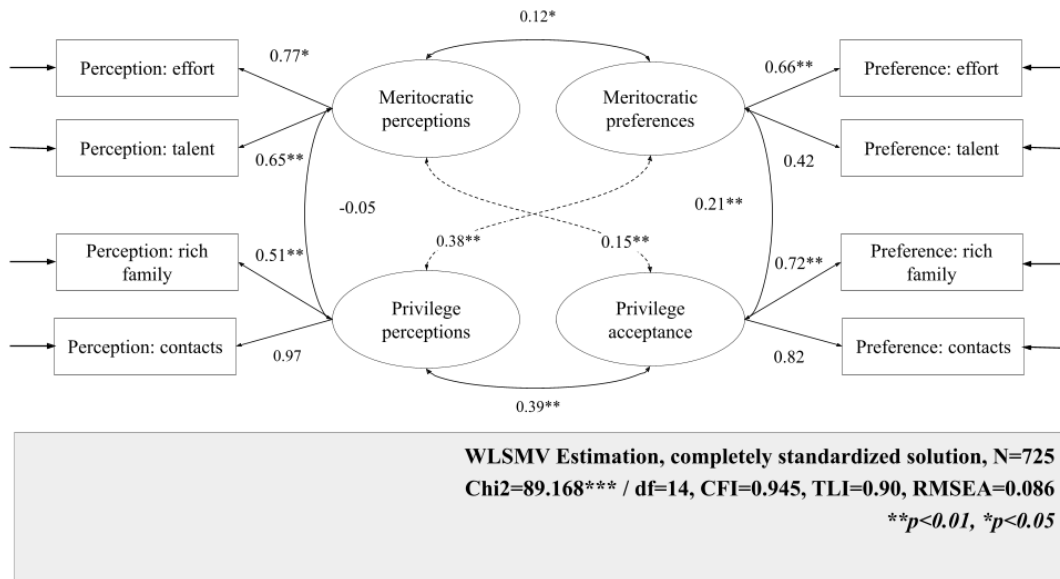
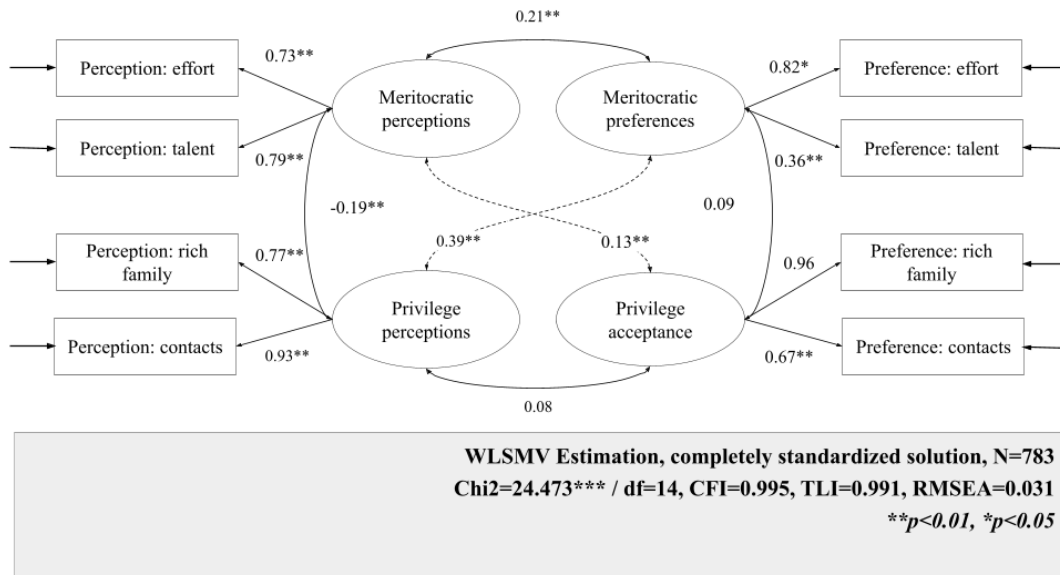


Figure 5: CFA model for the secondary cohort



3 Sources of misfit in longitudinal invariance

For the longitudinal strict invariance model (the more strict model), score tests provided no evidence of localized misfit. The global score test was non-significant, $\chi^2(20) = 11.93, p = .918$, and none of the univariate score tests for equality constraints was significant (all $p > .05$; smallest $p = .065$). This indicates that no single equality constraint notably contributed to the misfit. There are also no indicators of possible sources of misfit in the previous nested models (weak and strong).

4 Sources of misfit between cohort invariance

In contrast, score tests for the cross-cohort invariance constraints indicated localized misfit. The largest modification indices/score contributions clustered in the perceived effort, suggesting that equality constraints on thresholds/loadings for these items are not supported across school levels. Table 1 lists the ten constraints with the largest score statistics.

Table 1: Sources of misfit in longitudinal invariance

Item	Threshold	χ^2	df	p-value	p-value adjustment BH
Perception effort	t2	10.115134	1	0.0014706	0.0352936
Perception effort	t1	7.546618	1	0.0060123	0.0721474
Perception contact	t1	5.179947	1	0.0228490	0.1464457
Preference effort	t2	5.012861	1	0.0251597	0.1464457
Perception talent	t1	4.680351	1	0.0305095	0.1464457
Perception rich parents	t1	3.516226	1	0.0607707	0.2430828
Preference effort	t3	2.177777	1	0.1400165	0.4800567
Perception rich parents	t2	1.697639	1	0.1925971	0.5332262
Perception talent	t3	1.642668	1	0.1999598	0.5332262
Perception effort	t3	1.026312	1	0.3110265	0.7233287